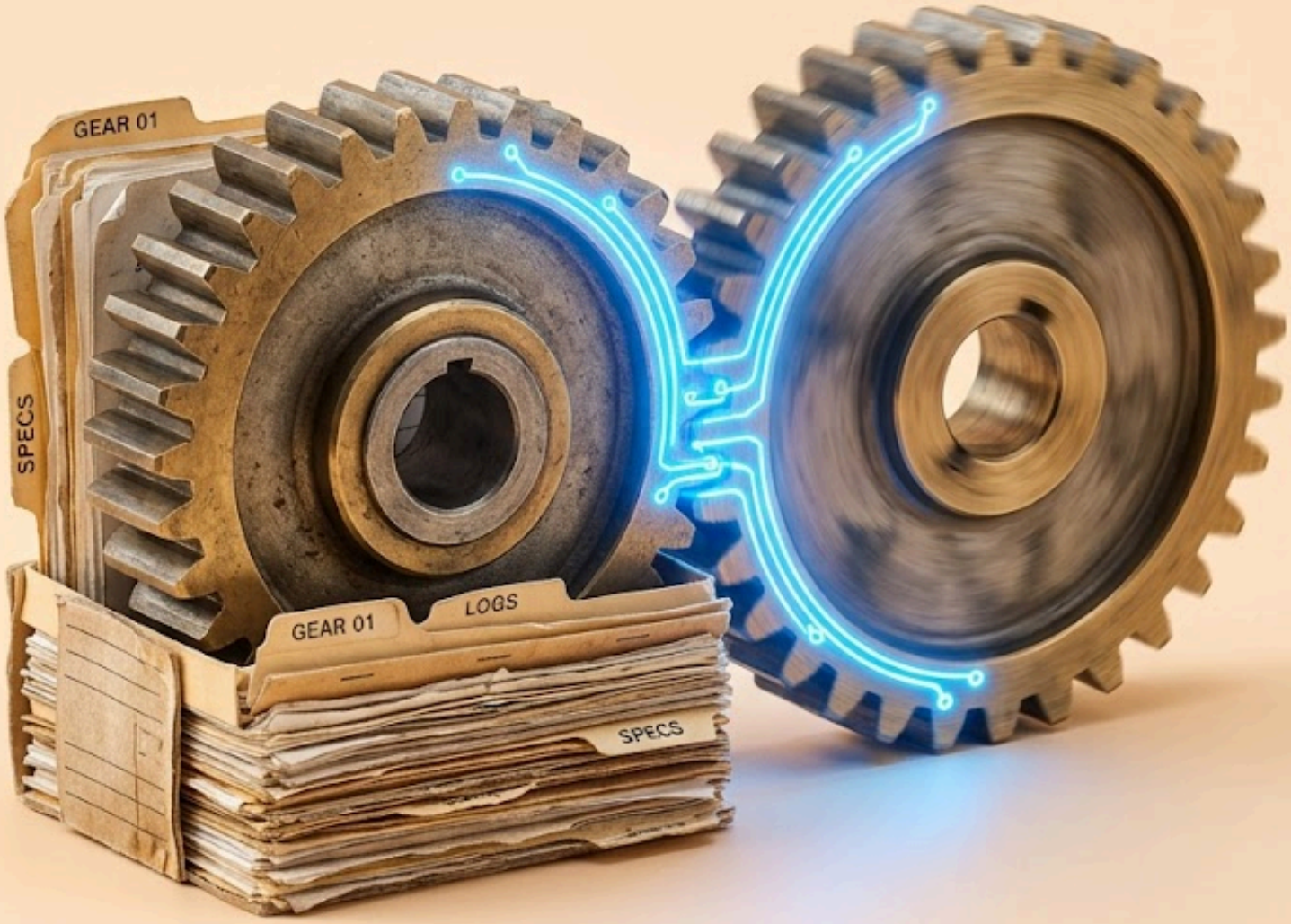
A LEADERSHIP IN CHANGE FIELD GUIDE

The NotebookLM Leader's Playbook

How to run the grounded engine like it's your own research team.

Joel Salinas



The NotebookLM Leader's Playbook

How to run the grounded engine like it's your own research team

A Leadership in Change field guide by Joel Salinas

Everybody's using AI now. That stopped being the edge a while ago.

This guide is about the part almost nobody does well: using the right engine for the job. You already know the generative side, the Claude or ChatGPT window where you reason and draft and create. This is the other engine. The grounded one. The one that reads only the sources you give it, cites every line, and won't make things up because it can't see past the material you handed it.

By the end, you'll be able to take a messy pile of sources, a stack of PDFs, a spreadsheet, seventeen YouTube videos, and turn it into one report you can actually trust, then hand that report up to your generative AI to build on solid ground.

Ground first. Then generate. That's the whole discipline, and it's what this playbook walks you through, step by step.

Written by a human, for humans.

THE TWO-ENGINE STACK

Ground, Then Generate

ENGINE 1 · GROUNDED

NotebookLM



Caged to your sources

Reads only what you give it. Synthesizes, cites every line, and won't invent a fact. This is where you build a report you can trust.

HAND IT UP



ENGINE 2 · GENERATIVE

Claude · Gemini



Free to reason and create

Takes your grounded report and does what it's great at: reasoning, strategy, drafting, building. Now it's building on solid ground.

Introduction: Two Engines, One Rule

So here's the mistake I made for a long time, and I watch a lot of us make it. I'd take whatever AI window I had open and make it do everything. Research, drafting, analysis, summarizing a stack of videos, all through the same tab. It kind of worked, so I never questioned it.

Then I picked up the right tool for one specific job and felt how much effort I'd been wasting. You can drive a nail with a wrench. It works, mostly. But the first time you use an actual hammer, you feel the difference in your arm. The wrench was never the problem. It was just built for a different swing.

Most serious AI work runs on two engines, and they're built for opposite jobs.

The grounded engine is NotebookLM. Google's research tool that only answers from the sources you personally give it. You hand it your documents, and it reads only those. It synthesizes, it cites the exact line it pulled from, and it won't invent a fact, because it can only see what you handed it. Its whole power is faithfulness to your sources.

The generative engine is Claude or Gemini or ChatGPT. This engine reasons, argues, drafts, and creates. It builds something new out of everything it knows. That range is its power, and it's also its risk, because an engine that can invent can invent a fact you needed to be true.

One is caged to your truth on purpose. The other roams free on purpose. And the rule that ties them together is the spine of this whole guide:

Ground first. Then generate.

Pull your real sources into the grounded engine, get a report you can trust, then hand that report up to the generative engine to reason and build on top of it. The facts come from the grounded side. The thinking happens on the generative side. That handoff is the two-engine stack working the way it's supposed to.

This playbook walks you through the grounded engine, NotebookLM, one move at a time, because that's the half most leaders have never actually run. You already know how to chat with Claude. Almost nobody knows how to ground first.

Find your starting line

You don't have to read this front to back. Find the line that sounds like you and start there.

If this is you right now...	Start at
"I've barely opened NotebookLM, or I opened it once and closed it."	**Section 1: Set up the grounded engine**
"I've got a notebook, but I'm not sure what to feed it or how."	**Section 2: Feed it the mess**
"My sources are in, but I'm not pulling real analysis out."	**Section 3: Interrogate and build the report**
"I trust my research, but the handoff to Claude is clumsy."	**Section 4: The handoff**

A quick note on plans, because it changed recently. As of July 2026, NotebookLM has a real free tier (up to 50 sources per notebook), which is plenty to run everything in the first three sections. The higher limits and the newest features ride on a paid Google AI plan. Start free. You won't hit the ceiling until you're already fluent.

Let's set up the first engine.

SECTION 1

Set Up the Grounded Engine

Your First Notebook



So the first thing to know is that there's almost nothing to set up. NotebookLM runs in your browser. You sign in with a Google account, you click one button, and you're in. If you've been putting this off because it felt like a tool you had to learn, that feeling ends in about ninety seconds.

The reason I want you to open it before you read another section is the same reason you don't learn to swim from a pamphlet. You understand this engine by watching it answer from your own sources, not by reading about it. So let's get you a live notebook.

Why this matters to you

A notebook in NotebookLM isn't a document. It's a workspace built around one set of sources. Think of it like a project folder that can read. You give it the material for one job, a client, a decision, a piece of research, and everything you ask inside that notebook is answered only from that material. Nothing leaks in from the open internet unless you invite it.

That boundary is the entire value. When you ask a question and the answer comes back tied to your sources, with a citation you can click, you stop wondering whether the AI made it up. You already know it didn't, because it had nowhere else to look. That trust is what you can't get from a generative engine, and it's why the grounded engine gets its own tool.

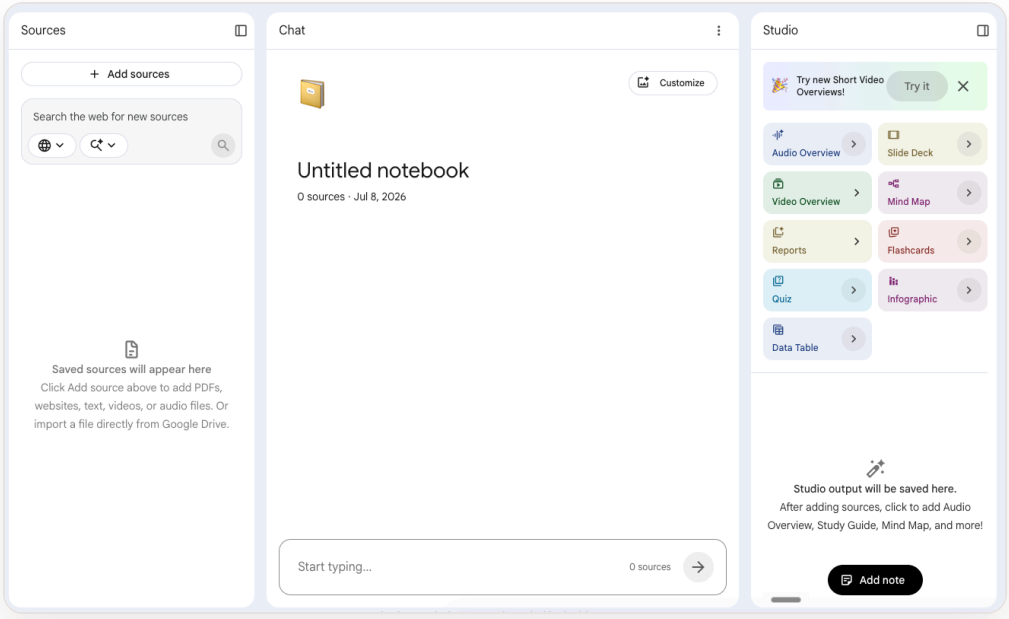


What the workspace actually is

Open a notebook and you'll see three panels, left to right. This is the whole tool, and the order is the workflow:

- **Sources** (**left**). The material you've given this notebook. Your grounding truth. Everything the AI can see lives here.
- **Chat** (**center**). Where you ask questions and get grounded, cited answers.
- **Studio** (**right**). Where you turn the notebook into finished formats: reports, audio and video overviews, slide decks, mind maps, data tables, and more. We'll get here in Section 3.

Left to right: put sources in, ask questions in the middle, produce something on the right. Once you see it that way, you never feel lost in it again.



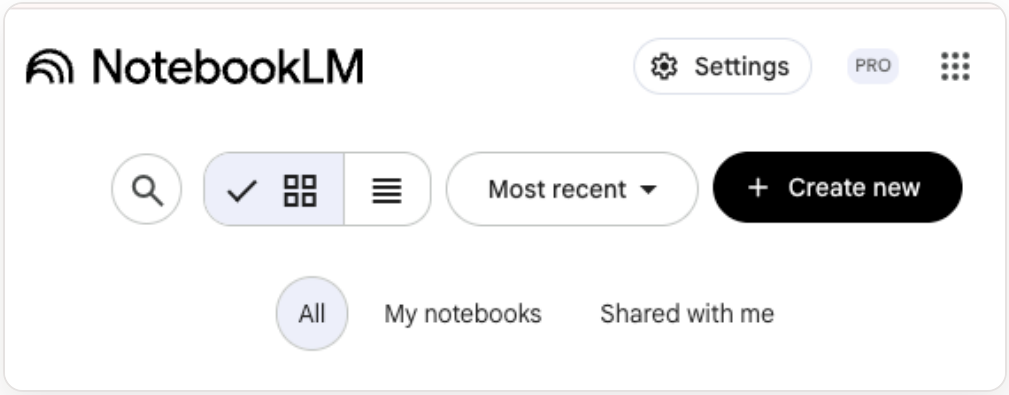
The whole workflow, left to right: Sources, Chat, Studio.

Walkthrough: open your first notebook

Do this now. It takes two minutes.

1. **Go to notebooklm.google.com** and sign in with your Google account.
2. **Click "Create new" (the new notebook button).** That's it. You've got a blank notebook.

3. **Look at the three panels.** Sources on the left is empty and asking for material. That's your next move, and it's the whole of Section 2.
4. **Name the notebook** for the actual job you're going to use it for. "Q3 competitor research," not "test." One notebook, one job.



Start here: one notebook per project.

How I think about it

I keep a notebook per real project, not a giant catch-all. When I'm researching something for one of my businesses, that gets its own notebook, and I don't muddy it with unrelated sources. The cleaner the sources in a notebook, the sharper every answer it gives back. A notebook stuffed with everything is a notebook that answers like it's guessing.

Two traps to avoid

- **Treating it like a second Claude.** If you open NotebookLM and start asking it to brainstorm or write from scratch, you're using the wrong engine. It's built to answer *from your sources*, not to invent. Feed it first.
- **One giant notebook for everything.** Mixing unrelated projects into one notebook dilutes every answer. One notebook, one job.

Your Challenge: Open It Tonight

Create one notebook, named for one real project you're working on this week. Don't add anything yet. Just get the workspace open and look at the three panels until the left-to-right flow feels obvious. That's the whole rep.

The Bridge

An empty notebook does nothing. The grounded engine only comes alive when you feed it, and what you feed it, and how you curate it, is where most of the quality is won or lost. That's next.

SECTION 2

Feed It the Mess

Sources In, Signal Out



So here's where the grounded engine earns its keep, and where most of us go wrong. We take a messy pile of material and either dump all of it in without thinking, or we never get past the one PDF we already had. The skill is in between: feed it real, varied sources, but curate them like they matter.

The good news is NotebookLM eats almost anything. You are not limited to clean documents.

Why this matters to you

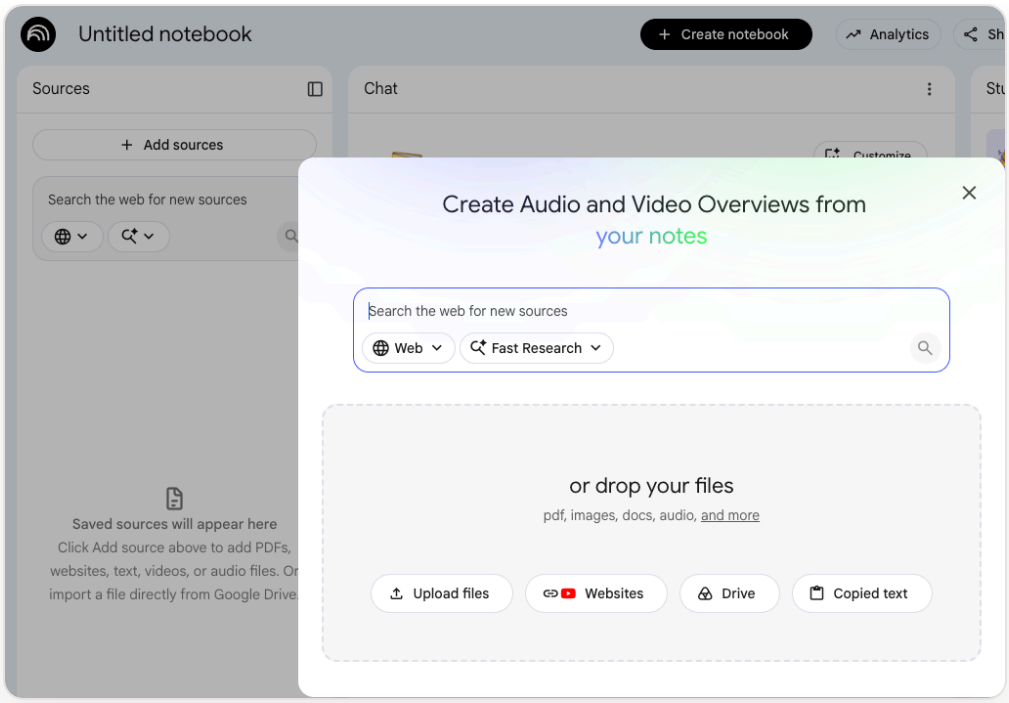
Your research is never in one place. It's a PDF report, a couple of Google Docs, a spreadsheet, a website, and three long YouTube videos you keep meaning to watch. Normally that scatter is the reason the analysis never happens. It's too much friction to hold it all in your head at once.

The grounded engine collapses that friction. It reads all of it, together, and lets you ask questions across the whole pile as if it were one document. The messier and more scattered your sources, the more this matters, because pulling one clear signal out of many sources is exactly the job a human finds slow and a grounded engine finds easy.

What counts as a source

As of July 2026, a single notebook on the free tier holds up to 50 sources, and each source can be enormous (up to half a million words). Paid Google AI plans raise that ceiling substantially (100, 300, even 600 sources per notebook), but 50 is more than enough to start. What you can add:

- **Documents:** PDFs, Word docs, Google Docs.
- **Data:** Google Sheets.
- **Slides:** Google Slides.
- **The web:** paste a website link, or paste raw text directly.
- **Video:** a YouTube link. NotebookLM reads the video's transcript, so public videos with captions come right in.
- **Images.**

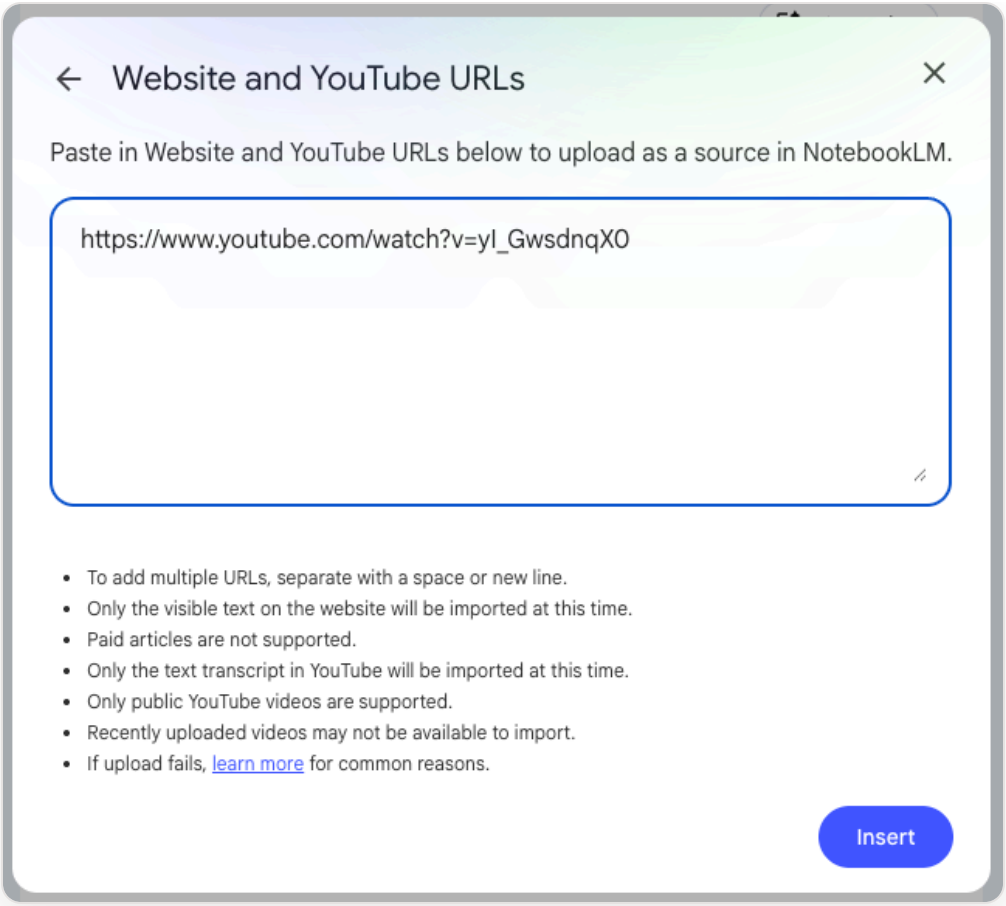


Everything's a source: PDFs, Docs, websites, pasted text, even YouTube.

One thing worth knowing: sources you connect from Google Drive (Docs, Slides, Sheets) can sync. If you edit the original doc, the notebook pulls the update, usually within a few minutes on desktop. A PDF you upload is frozen at upload. So for anything that's still changing, connect the living Google Drive version instead of exporting a static file.

Walkthrough: feed your notebook

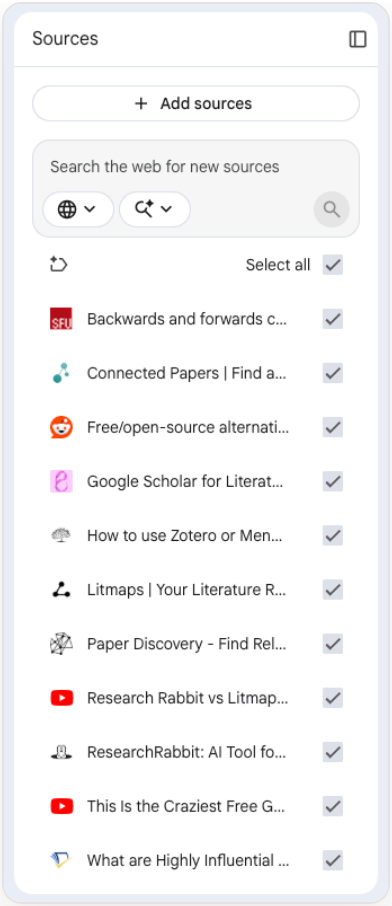
1. **Open your notebook and click "Add source"** (top of the Sources panel on the left).
2. **Pick your type.** Upload a file, connect a Google Doc or Sheet, paste a link, or paste text.
3. **Add a YouTube video.** Choose the YouTube option and paste the URL. This is the one that surprises people. A sixty-minute video becomes a source you can question in seconds.
4. **Add a few more.** Build a real pile: a report, a doc, a couple of videos. You want variety, because the interesting answers come from connecting across different sources.
5. **Curate as you go.** This is the discipline: don't dump forty half-relevant links. A tight set of strong sources beats a huge set of weak ones every time. If a source is noise, leave it out. You're protecting the signal.



Drop a YouTube link straight in. It reads the whole video.

How I use it

When I'm doing real research, I'll pull seventeen or eighteen sources into one notebook, including full YouTube videos, and let it read all of them. That's the move that used to be impossible. I'm not watching three hours of video and skimming five reports and trying to hold it together in my head. I put it all in one place and let the grounded engine hold it for me. Then I start asking.



A real research notebook: seventeen sources in one place.

Two traps to avoid

- **Dumping without curating.** More sources isn't better. Relevant sources are better. Every weak source you add pulls the average answer toward noise.
- **Uploading static files that are still changing.** If a doc is live and evolving, connect it from Google Drive so the notebook stays current. Upload a frozen PDF only when the source is genuinely final.

Your Challenge: Load One Real Pile

Take one decision or question you're facing this week and load the notebook with the real sources behind it. Include at least one YouTube video, because that's the capability you've probably never used. Aim for five to ten strong sources, not forty weak ones.

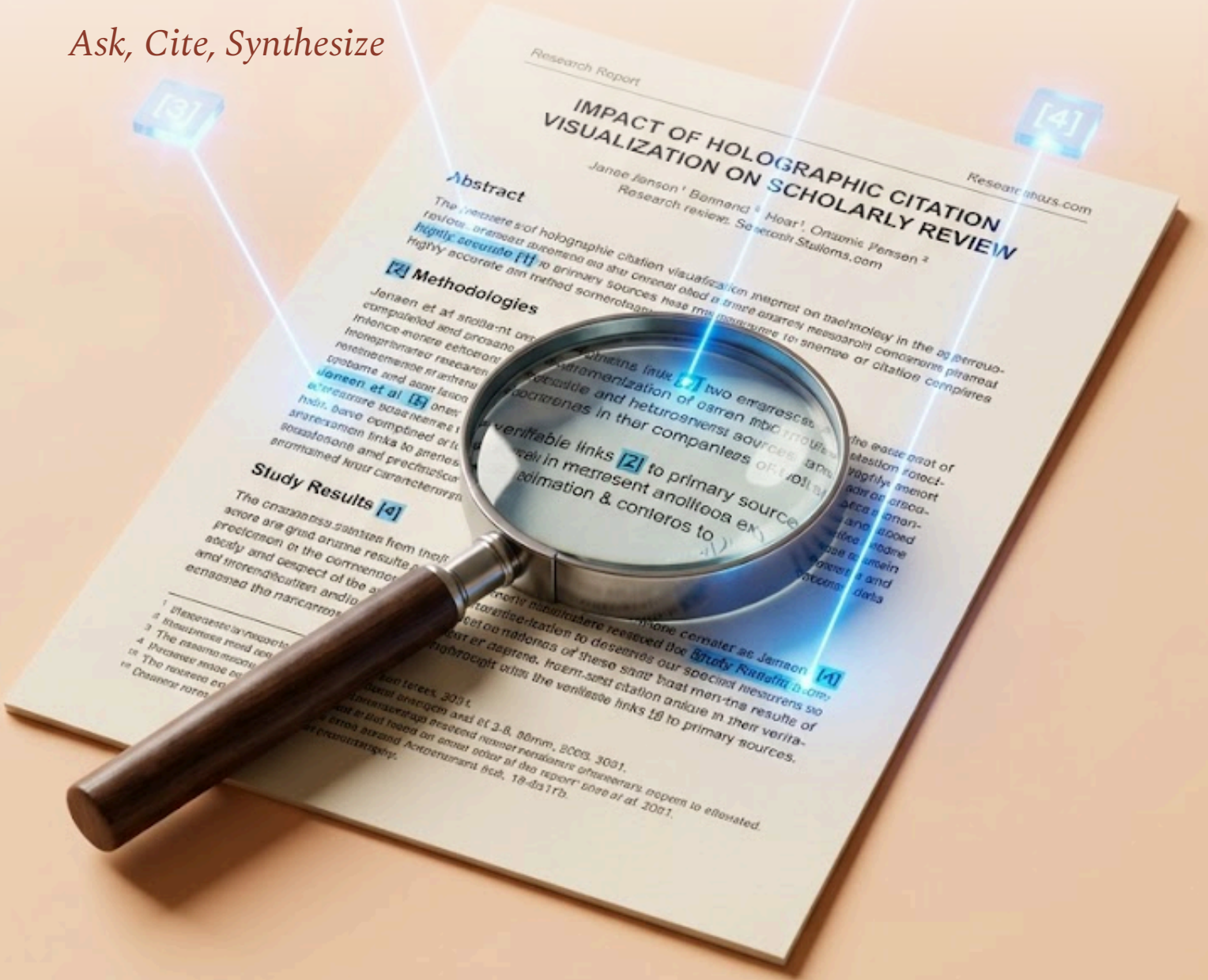
The Bridge

Now the notebook is full and it's holding more than you could hold in your head. That's potential, not payoff. The payoff comes when you start interrogating it and turn all that raw material into one report you can trust. That's the heart of the whole thing, and it's next.

SECTION 3

Interrogate & Build the Report

Ask, Cite, Synthesize



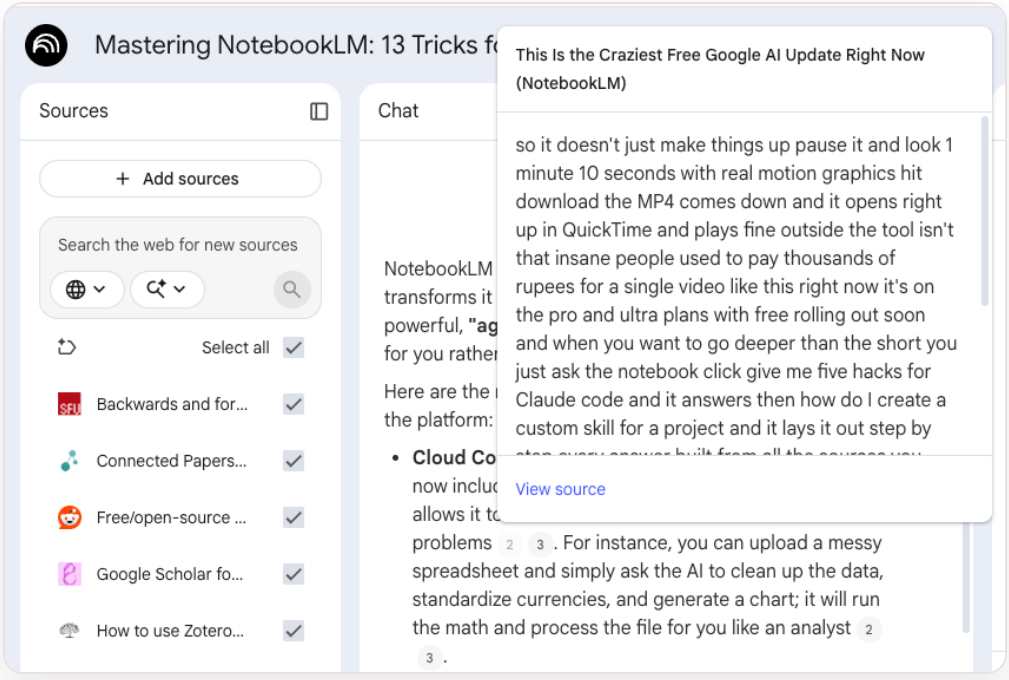
So this is the section that changes how you work. You've got a notebook full of real material. Now you get to ask it anything, and every answer comes back tied to your sources, with a receipt.

The generative engine answers from everything it's ever seen. The grounded engine answers from what's in front of it, and shows you where it got each piece. That difference is the whole reason we're here. Let's use it.

Why this matters to you

Think about the last time an AI gave you a confident answer and you had no idea whether to believe it. That doubt is expensive. You either trust it and risk being wrong in front of your board, or you go re-verify it by hand and lose the time the AI was supposed to save.

Grounded answers remove that tax. When NotebookLM tells you something, there's a little numbered citation next to it. Click it, and you land on the exact line in the exact source it pulled from. You're not trusting the AI. You're checking its work in one click. That's the difference between a tool you use for fun and a tool you'll put your name behind.



Every claim comes with a receipt. Those numbers are real citations.

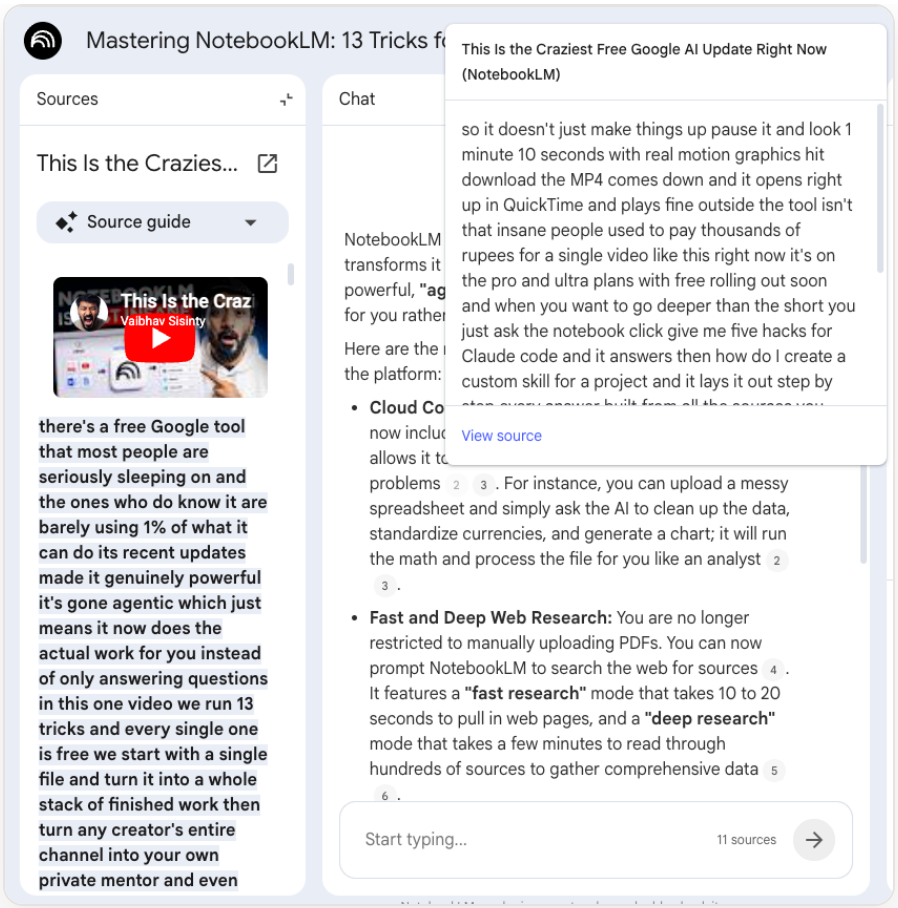
What interrogating actually looks like

Start in the Chat panel in the center. Ask real questions across your sources, the kind you'd ask a sharp analyst who'd read everything:

- "What do these sources agree on, and where do they contradict each other?"
- "Pull every specific number mentioned about pricing, with the source for each."
- "What's the strongest argument against the main claim in these documents?"

Two things worth turning on:

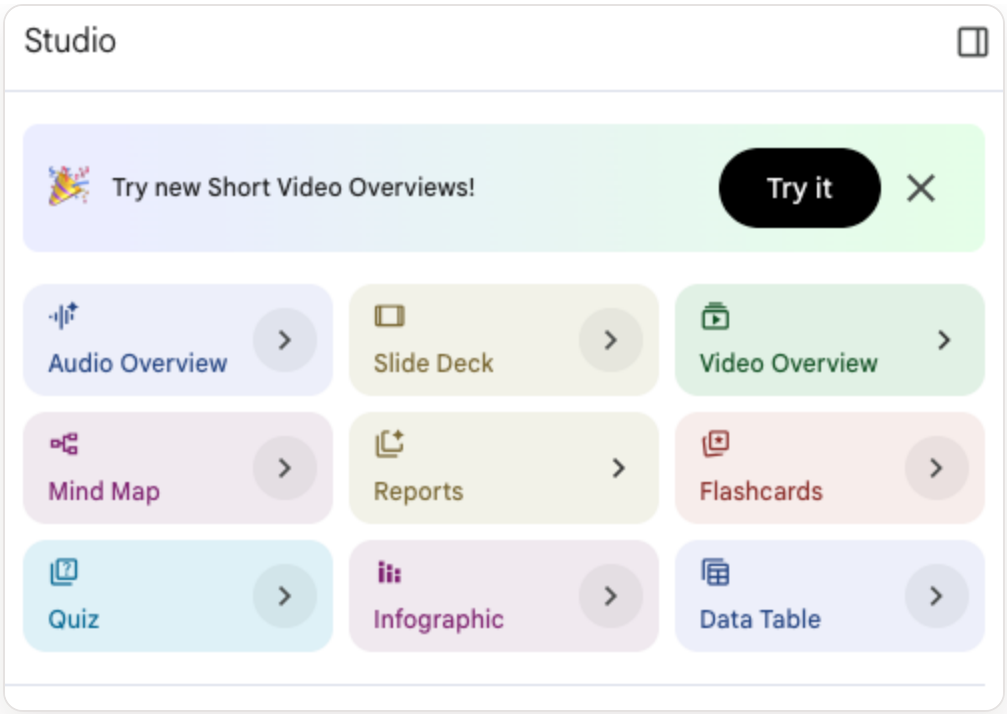
- **Configure Chat.** You can set the response style (a straight default, a learning-guide style, or a custom persona you define) and the length. For serious work, tell it to act like the specific kind of analyst you need and to always cite. Custom instructions carry across your notebook.
- **Notes.** When an answer is worth keeping, save it as a note. Your notes become part of the notebook, so you're building up a layer of your own thinking on top of the sources.



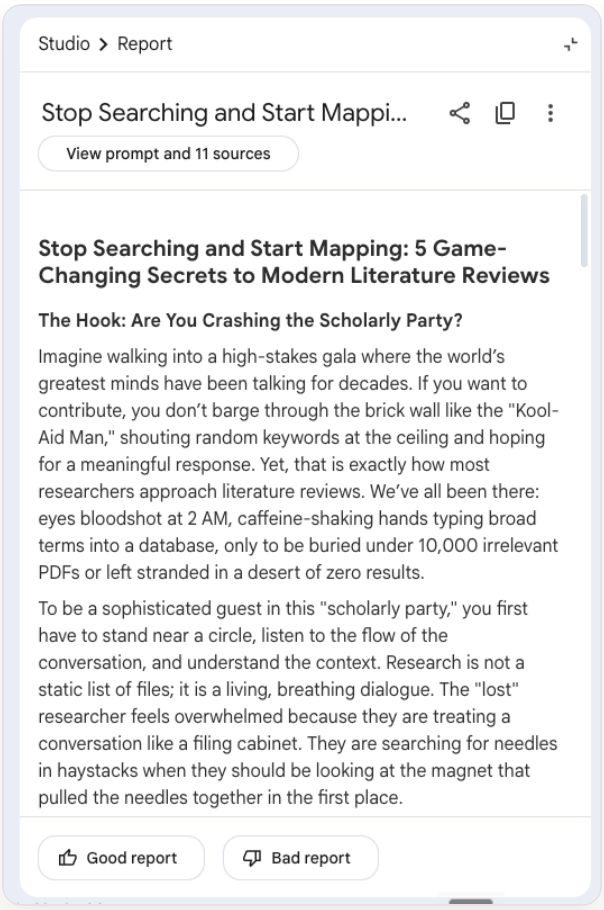
Click the number, land on the exact line it pulled from.

Walkthrough: from questions to one report

1. **Ask three or four real questions** in the Chat panel. Read the answers. Click a citation or two and confirm it landed on the right line. Build your trust in the tool.
2. **Save the good answers as notes.**
3. **Open the Studio panel on the right.** This is where the notebook turns into finished formats: Reports, Audio and Video Overviews, Slide Decks, Mind Maps, Data Tables, Infographics, Quizzes, and Flashcards.
4. **Generate a Report.** This is your workhorse. It reads across every source and produces a structured, synthesized briefing, and because it's the grounded engine, everything in it traces back to a source you chose. No invented statistics. No confident filler.
5. **Refine it.** If the report misses an angle, ask for it. Tell it to go deeper on one section, or to pull the data into a table.



The Studio turns your grounded notebook into finished formats.



One synthesized report, built only from sources you chose.

A note on the newest power feature

If you're on a higher Google AI plan (Ultra, at time of writing), NotebookLM added a genuinely new capability in June 2026: a secure cloud computer inside the notebook that can write and run code on your sources. It cleans messy spreadsheets, builds charts, and exports finished files like Excel or PDF, without you writing a line of code. It's not on every plan yet, so I'm flagging it rather than building the guide around it. If you have it, it turns the grounded engine into a data analyst too.

How I use it

The report is the thing I actually carry forward. I'll take seventeen sources, ask my questions, then have it build one synthesized report. That report is now my trustworthy foundation. Everything I do next, the strategy, the drafting, the decisions, starts from that grounded document instead of from a blank page and a guess.

Your Challenge: Generate One Trustworthy Report

From the notebook you loaded in Section 2, ask three real questions, check the citations, then generate a Report. Read it and confirm you'd be comfortable putting a claim from it in front of someone who matters. That comfort is the signal that you've grounded it right.

The Bridge

You've got a report you trust. Here's the last move, and it's the one that ties the two engines together: handing that grounded work up to Claude to reason and build on. That's the handoff, and it's where the whole stack pays off.

SECTION 4

The Handoff

Ground, Then Generate



So this is the move that makes it a stack instead of two separate tools. You've got a report you trust, built from your own sources, every claim cited. Now you hand it up to the generative engine and let it do what it's great at: reasoning, strategy, drafting, building. The facts came from the grounded side. The thinking happens on the generative side. That's the two-engine stack in one motion.

Here's why the order matters so much. If you skip the grounding and dump raw sources straight into Claude, it blends real facts with plausible-sounding filler, and you can't always tell which is which. But if you hand Claude a report that's *already* grounded and cited, it reasons on top of solid material. Same generative power, none of the drift.

Why this matters to you

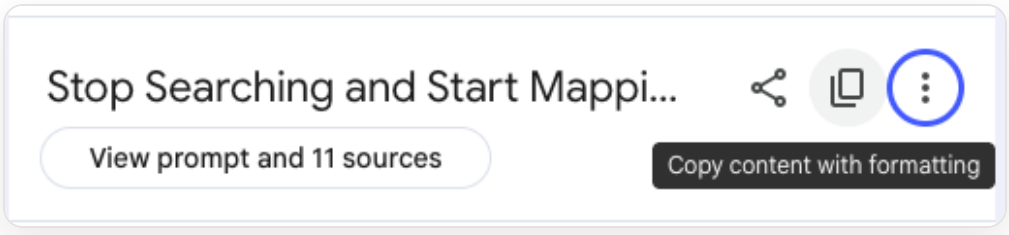
This is where most of your actual output gets made. The strategy memo, the board narrative, the plan, the draft. None of that comes out of the grounded engine, which is built to be faithful, not creative. It comes out of the generative engine. So the whole point of grounding first was to get to this handoff with material you can build on without fear.

Do it in the right order and you get the best of both: the accuracy of the grounded engine and the range of the generative one. Skip the order and you get a fast draft you have to fact-check line by line, which is the tax we were trying to avoid.

The simple way: copy and paste

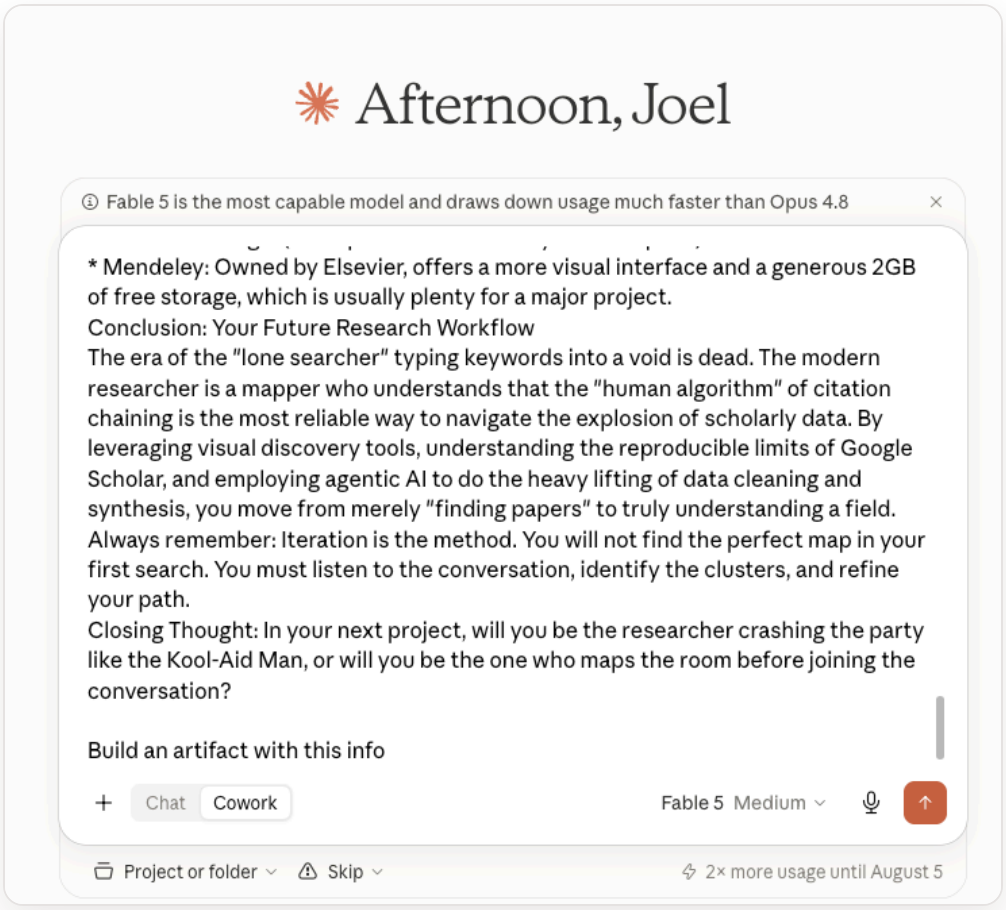
Start here. It works, and it teaches you the rhythm.

1. **In NotebookLM, open your report** and copy it out, or export it.
2. **Open Claude.** Paste the report in.
3. **Give Claude its job** on top of that grounded material.



Copy the grounded report out. This is the handoff.

Above the report, tell Claude what to do with it and make the grounding explicit. Something like: *"Here's a research report I've already grounded in real sources. Use only what's in it, and don't add any fact it doesn't support. Now draft the board summary."* That one instruction is what turns trustworthy research into finished thinking, with the facts still locked down.



Paste the grounded report into Claude and let it build on solid ground.

How I use it

Most of my day lives in Claude. Four businesses run through it. But the moment a job depends on getting the facts right from real sources, I ground it in NotebookLM first, then hand it up. The report comes out of the grounded engine. The strategy, the writing, the build, all of that happens in Claude, on top of ground I already trust.

Two traps to avoid

- **Skipping the grounding.** If you paste raw sources into Claude and ask it to reason, you're back to mixing fact and filler. Ground first, always, then hand up.
- **Waiting for a fancier setup.** Don't let "I should automate this" stop you from just doing it. Copy-paste is a real, complete workflow. Run it as-is.

Your Challenge: Run the Full Stack Once

Take the report you built in Section 3, paste it into Claude with a real instruction, and produce one finished thing: a memo, a plan, a draft. Notice that you never had to fact-check it against the void, because the facts were grounded before Claude ever touched them. That's the stack. Once you've felt it once, you won't work the old way again.

The Bridge

You've run all four moves. The last thing is to make this a habit instead of a one-time trick, so the next section is a simple three-week plan to wire the two-engine stack into how you actually work.

10 Grounded-Engine Plays for Leaders

So you've got the four moves. Here's where they pay off. These are ten real jobs a leader can hand to the grounded engine this month, each one a case where being faithful to your sources matters more than being clever. Pick the two or three closest to your actual work and run them.

1. Board prep from a pile. Drop every source behind an upcoming board conversation into one notebook, the reports, the memos, the market data, and ask for the three things the board will push on. Every answer traces to a source, so you walk in able to defend each number.

2. Contract and policy review. Load a contract, an MSA, or a new policy and ask exactly what it says about the clause you care about, renewal terms, liability, notice periods. The citation takes you to the line. You still bring it to your lawyer, but you walk in knowing where to look.

3. Meeting accountability. Feed in your meeting transcripts (the ones your notetaker already generates) and ask who committed to what, and by when. Because it's grounded, the follow-ups are anchored to what was actually said, not what everyone half-remembers.

4. Competitive and market intelligence. Load competitor pages, analyst notes, earnings summaries, and a few long YouTube breakdowns, then ask where the sources agree and where they contradict each other. The contradictions are usually where the real insight is.

5. Multi-year trend tracking. Put three or four years of the same report side by side, annual reviews, budgets, survey results, and ask what changed and what quietly stayed the same. Patterns across time are exactly what a human eye misses and a grounded engine catches.

6. Financial statement synthesis. Load the statements and ask for the specific figures, with the source line for each, before you build the narrative. Ground the numbers first, then let the generative engine write the story on top of them.

7. Grant, RFP, or proposal synthesis. Drop the full RFP plus your past winning proposals into one notebook and ask what this funder actually requires and which of your existing

language already answers it. Faithful beats creative when a single missed requirement disqualifies you.

8. A living team knowledge base. Connect your standing Google Docs (the ones that keep changing) so the notebook stays current, and let your team ask it questions instead of pinging you. Because Drive sources sync, the answers stay up to date on their own.

9. Onboarding a new hire or a new engagement. Load the background, the org's documents, the history, and let the new person interrogate it directly. They get grounded answers with citations instead of a week of your time.

10. Longitudinal personal tracking. On a personal note, some leaders load years of their own health reports or financial records to flag subtle changes over time. Same principle: real sources, cited answers, no invented numbers. (Keep anything sensitive in a private notebook.)

The thread through all ten is the same. When the cost of a made-up detail is high, you want the engine that can't make things up. Ground it, cite it, then decide.

Common Pitfalls (and the Fix)

So here are the mistakes I see most often, including a few I made myself. None of them are fatal. Each one has a one-line fix, and knowing them ahead of time will save you the frustration that makes people quit a tool too early.

Pitfall 1: Dumping instead of curating. You throw forty half-relevant sources into a notebook and the answers get muddy. *The fix:* a tight set of strong sources beats a huge set of weak ones. Every source you add pulls the average answer toward it, so protect the signal.

Pitfall 2: Using it like a second Claude. You open the grounded engine and ask it to brainstorm or write from scratch, then wonder why it feels flat. *The fix:* that's a generative job. The grounded engine answers *from your sources*. If there's nothing to be faithful to, you're in the wrong engine.

Pitfall 3: Trusting the answer without clicking the citation. The whole point of grounding is the receipt, and most people never click it. *The fix:* on anything that matters, click one or two citations and confirm the answer landed on the right line. It takes five seconds and it's the difference between "the AI said so" and "I checked."

Pitfall 4: Uploading static files that are still changing. You export a Google Doc to PDF, upload it, and a week later the notebook is working from a stale version. *The fix:* connect the living Google Drive source instead of exporting. It syncs on its own. Upload a frozen file only when the source is genuinely final.

Pitfall 5: Skipping the grounding on high-stakes work. You're in a hurry, so you paste raw sources straight into the generative engine and let it reason. Now you can't tell which facts are real. *The fix:* ground first, then generate. Always, when being wrong is expensive.

Pitfall 6: Over-engineering the setup. You get stuck trying to automate the whole handoff before you've ever run the basic workflow. *The fix:* copy-paste is a complete, real workflow. Get fluent there first; automate later, if at all.

The pattern behind every fix is the same discipline the whole playbook rests on. Know which engine you're holding, feed it well, and check its work. Do that and the grounded engine becomes the most trustworthy tool in your stack.

Where This Fits: The Bigger Picture

So let's zoom out for a second, because the two-engine stack isn't really about NotebookLM. The tool will change. The buttons will move, the features will get renamed, and a year from now some of the screenshots in this guide will look dated. What won't change is the skill underneath it, which is knowing what job you're doing and reaching for the right kind of tool to do it.

That skill is the whole reason I write about this. It's the heart of what I call the AI Leadership Triad, the three things I think separate leaders who thrive in this era from leaders who get run over by it: Adaptability, Innovation, and Creativity. The two-engine stack is where all three show up in one small, practical habit.

Adaptability is picking the right engine instead of forcing one tool to do everything. The leader who only knows the generative engine keeps driving nails with a wrench and calling it good enough. The adaptable one notices the job changed and switches tools. That's not a technical skill. It's a posture, and it's learnable.

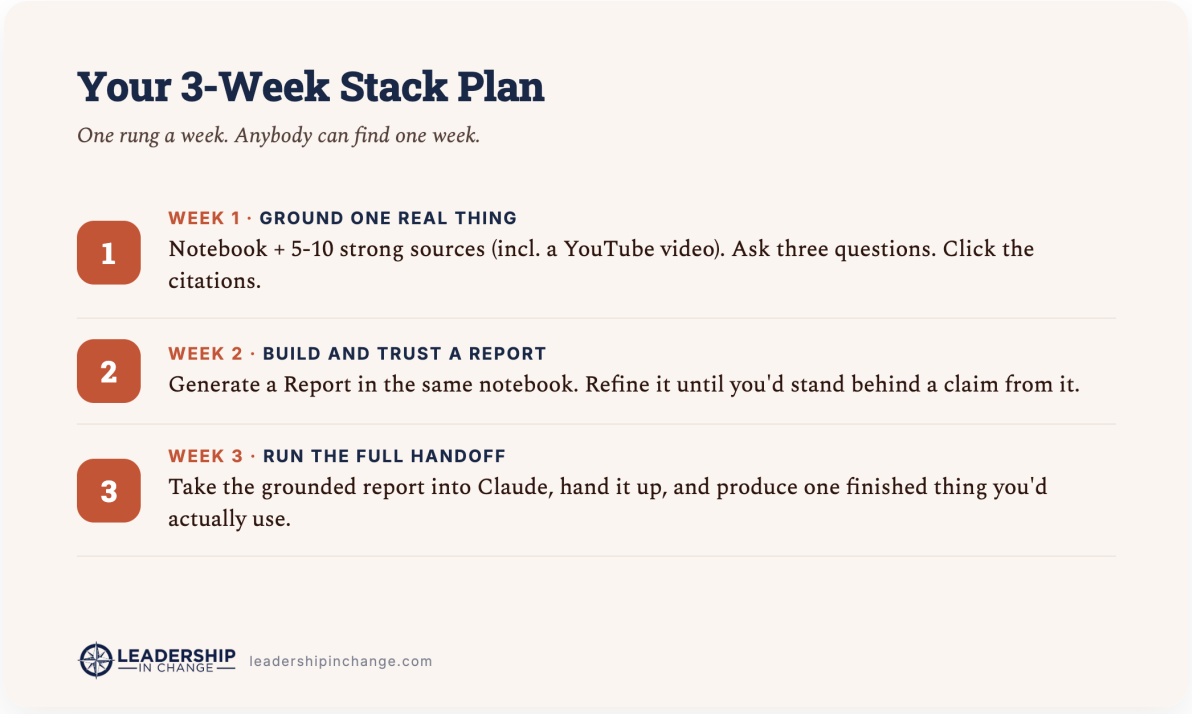
Innovation is what grounding makes safe. Most of us hold back from experimenting with AI on real work because we're afraid it'll invent something and we'll look foolish. Ground the work first and that fear drops, because now the facts are locked to your sources. Safe ground is what lets you actually try things.

Creativity is what the generative engine is for, and it gets *better* when it's standing on solid ground. When Claude isn't guessing at the facts, it can spend all of its range on the thinking, the angle, the argument, the thing only you were going to ask for. Ground first, and your creative work has something true to build on.

That's the real takeaway, the one worth keeping after the features change. Using AI isn't the edge anymore. Knowing which kind to reach for, and in what order, is. Ground first, then generate, and you're not just running a tool. You're leading the way you'll need to lead for the next decade.

Your 3-Week Stack Plan

So you've seen all four moves. The difference between reading a guide and actually changing how you work is small and boring: you do one rep a week until it's a habit. Here's the plan I'd give you. One week per rung. Anybody can find one week.



Three weeks. One rung at a time.

Week 1: Ground one real thing. Pick one genuine project. Create a notebook, load five to ten strong sources, including at least one YouTube video, and ask it three real questions. Click the citations. The only goal this week is to feel the difference between a grounded answer and a generative guess.

Week 2: Build and trust a report. In that same notebook, generate a Report. Read it, check that you'd stand behind a claim from it, and refine the weak sections. This week you're learning to turn a pile of sources into one document you trust.

Week 3: Run the full handoff. Take your grounded report into Claude, hand it up with a real instruction, and produce one finished thing you'd actually use. This is the whole

stack, start to finish, on real work. Once you've done it once on something that matters, it stops being a technique and becomes the way you work.

That's it. Three weeks, three reps, and you're running a two-engine stack that most leaders don't even know exists.

Everybody's using AI now. That stopped being the edge a while ago. Using the right engine for the job is the edge, and now you've got both.

Where to go next

If you want to keep sharpening this every week, the deeper workflows, the prompts, the newest features as they ship, that's what I publish for premium members of Leadership in Change. It's $49 a year, and this guide is part of what comes with it, along with the full prompt and skill library. **Become a premium member here**.

And if you want this built properly into how your team researches and decides, faster and with fewer wrong turns than you'd manage alone, that's the work I do one-on-one with leaders. **Start with a free discovery call at jsalinas.org/call**.

Not sure where you stand with AI yet? Take the free **AI Leadership Compass** first. It shows you where you sit on two axes: how you think about AI, and how much you've actually put it to work.

Ground first. Then generate. See you in the stack.

Quick Reference

Keep this page. It's the whole playbook on one screen.

Which engine for which job

The job in front of you	The engine	Why
Stick to these exact sources, don't wander	**Grounded (NotebookLM)**	Answers only from what you gave it, cites every line
Synthesize a messy pile into one report	**Grounded (NotebookLM)**	Reads across all sources at once, no invented facts
Fact-check a claim against real material	**Grounded (NotebookLM)**	Click the citation, land on the source line
Reason, argue, draft, create	**Generative (Claude / Gemini)**	Builds something new from everything it knows
Turn grounded research into a memo or plan	**Generative (Claude / Gemini)**	Best at thinking on top of solid material

The rule: ground first, then generate.

NotebookLM Studio outputs (as of July 2026)

What the notebook can produce once it's loaded. Names and formats verified against Google's current documentation.

Output	Use it for
Reports	Your workhorse. A synthesized, cited briefing across every source.
Audio Overview	A spoken walkthrough. Formats: Deep Dive, Brief, Critique, Debate.
Video Overview	A narrated visual summary. Formats: Cinematic, Explainer, Short.
Slide Decks	Presenter Slides or a Detailed Deck. Exports as editable PDF and PPTX.

Output	Use it for
Mind Maps	A bird's-eye map of the notebook you can click into.
Data Tables	Pulls scattered data into sortable tables, exportable to Google Sheets.
Infographics	Visual one-pagers. Detail levels: Concise, Standard, Detailed.
Quizzes / Flashcards	Turn sources into fact-based study tools for a team or a workshop.

Source limits by plan (as of July 2026)

Plan	Sources per notebook
Free / Standard	50
NotebookLM Plus (Google AI Plus)	100
NotebookLM Pro (Google AI Pro)	300
NotebookLM Ultra (Google AI Ultra)	600

Each source can run up to about 500,000 words. Higher plans also unlock the newest features, including the in-notebook cloud computer that runs code on your sources.

The four moves, one more time

Set up a notebook (one per real project), **feed it** strong curated sources including YouTube videos, **interrogate** it and check the citations to build one trustworthy report, then **hand it off** to Claude to reason and build on solid ground. Ground first. Then generate.

Joel Salinas is an AI Strategy Coach for leaders at small and mid-sized businesses and nonprofits. 1:1 coaching, team workshops, and AI strategy work built around amplifying what your team is already good at. Creator of the AI Leadership Triad. He writes Leadership in Change. Written by a human, for humans.

Ready to build this into your work?

You've got the whole stack now: ground the mess, then generate on top of it. If you want it wired into how your team actually researches and decides, faster and with fewer wrong turns than you'd manage alone, that's the work I do one-on-one with leaders.

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Find your starting point · the AI Leadership Compass · compass.jsalinas.org



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